

Episode 77: Once Upon a Time... (48) – First, I Bought "Lonely Planet Fiji"

The other day, I went to Seoul to meet some friends.

I occasionally meet up like this with Korean friends I used to work with. Incidentally, they're two young women (laughs). With their escort, I always get to enjoy a Seoul that's different from regular tourist travel - going to art museums, strolling through fashionable districts, eating delicious food at local restaurants.

Really though, Korea and Seoul are so close. The flight time is about 2 hours. You arrive with roughly the same sense of distance as going to Fukuoka or somewhere. And when you arrive, the scenery isn't that different from Japan. The skin colour of people passing by is the same as Japanese people, and it doesn't feel that different from places like Osaka or Hakata that I visited recently. Oh yes, they stand on the right side of escalators too (laughs).

But what's definitely different are the characters overflowing on signs throughout the city. Wow, I can't read them at all > Hangul (laughs). I took the subway alone from the airport, but you know, I couldn't understand anything at all. Seoul's subway also has "serial numbers" for stations like Tokyo's, so I managed to reach my destination relying on those.

Ah! I see!

Foreigners coming to Tokyo must feel exactly the same way. I realised for the first time the importance of those subway station "serial numbers."

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home was restarted with "protagonist = Japanese" according to the original work. The staff room we had set up was still far from being busy. The crucial scenario

itself was still in progress, and various settings were barely getting started. I myself was actually busier with other works (like theatrical *Dragon Ball Z*, etc.).

In terms of colour direction (colour design), ultimately there's no way to work until character settings come out, so I could only wait for settings to start appearing. Even so, to be proactive, I reread the original work... well, that was about it (laughs).

Meanwhile, the director and main staff (planning producer Tamiya-san, animation director, art director) went on location scouting to Fiji and Tahiti, where the story takes place.

As expected, I wasn't taken along for colour direction (tears). Too bad. According to what I heard from the director later, it was an extremely tight and demanding location scout, but even so, the beautiful ocean and coral reefs seen from above in the aeroplane were absolutely wonderful.

Lucky them.

Actually, at that time I had never gone overseas yet. I didn't even have a passport. I'm sure if it were now, I would have said "I'll pay my own way to go on the location scout!" (laughs).

Ah, no, I think I actually said something like that back then too... (laughs).

But anyway, in the end I wasn't taken along (actually, I couldn't go even if I wanted to because of work on Director Nishio's theatrical *Dragon Ball Z*), so I reluctantly started gathering materials about Fiji and Tahiti bit by bit.

First, visuals. When you think about gathering overseas materials, you start with bookstores. You dig through photo books and such publications. But they're expensive!

Proper photo books certainly have good prices attached. So expensive you can't easily afford them. Back then, there wasn't the convenient thing called the Internet like today.

Since I wasn't taken on the location scout, I was getting impatient, but when I thought about what materials I actually needed, "...(sweat)" I didn't really understand it myself (laughs).

Then one day, I encountered a book. It was *Lonely Planet Fiji* (地球の歩き方・フィジー).

The travel guidebook contained exactly the information I (probably) wanted, packed tight. The regional divisions might have changed now, but I'm sure this book contained information about the Fiji Islands and Tahiti.

As you probably know, this *Lonely Planet* series - honestly, the photos aren't that beautiful, and even when included, they're quite small. Even so, I felt I could somehow sense the local atmosphere, so I absorbed all the information into my head.

I've never read a travel guide so thoroughly from corner to corner, before or since. How thoroughly did I read it? Well, I could accurately draw the main area map of Papeete in Tahiti without looking at anything! Even the locations of recommended Chinese restaurants were firmly in my head (laughs).

A very useful guidebook. It became the first overseas travel guidebook I ever bought in my life. However, I still haven't been able to visit the places introduced in this book.

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